

GETTY IMAGES

**CASTING A WIDE NET**
An enumerator collecting caste data at a Patna home, Aug. 2023

cate things for both NDA and I.N.D.I.A. partners. The Maratha-Kunbis are a numerically large (estimated to be over 30 per cent of the state's population) and socially and politically powerful community in Maharashtra. While the undivided Shiv Sena was seen as a party of the OBCs and the poor Marathas, the urban, Mumbai-based leadership of the Uddhav Thackeray faction had failed to formulate a coherent response to the demands and counter-demands for reservation. And though CM Shinde has managed to project himself as a leader of the subaltern Marathas for the moment, his move is likely to create resentment among other OBCs. At least 5.7 million Marathas are expected to be added to the state's OBC population, shrinking opportunities for the existing OBCs. And though the Marathas have historically supported the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), Chhagan Bhujbal, a leader of the Ajit Pawar faction of the party that has allied with the NDA in Maharashtra, has warned of a counter-mobilisation by the OBCs.

## END OF THE I.N.D.I.A. STORY?

Caste aside, I.N.D.I.A. has been unable to offer voters either novelty or an effective counter on issues. Opposition parties have long been mute spectators or reduced to nit-picking, often to their disadvantage. Like in September, when the BJP stole a march over them by announcing 33 per cent reservation for women in the national and state legislatures. Women voters have emerged as a deciding factor in the past several elections. Nitish, too, has nurtured the constituency in his state since 2005 with women-centric schemes. And, as political analyst Rahul Verma says, quoting survey data, Nitish gains from the women's vote when he contests with the BJP, rather than the RJD. Thus women voted for the BJP-JD(U) combine in the 2019 Lok Sabha and 2020 assembly elections, but not in the 2015 state election, when the JD(U) contested with the RJD.

Even on other major issues, there is no consensus among I.N.D.I.A. partners, which sends mixed signals to voters. In the case of CAA, for instance, the Congress and TMC are opposed to the legislation, but Uddhav Thackeray supports it. On the Uniform Civil Code, Thackeray and AAP are in favour but the Congress and TMC have steered clear of expressing a decisive stand. Meanwhile, the ban on triple talaq earlier is said to have won the BJP some support among Muslim women.

As for the one thing that Rahul may have hoped would prove Modi's Achilles' heel—the industrialist Gautam Adani, whose fortunes have soared during the Modi years—the narrative has failed to stick either to Modi or Adani. NCP leader Sharad Pawar had a contrarian take on US short-seller Hindenburg Research's report alleging stock market manipulation by the Adani Group. He even dismissed the high-pitched campaign by the Congress and other Opposition parties for a joint parliamentary committee probe that had stalled all business in Parliament during last year's budget session. "The minimum that the Opposition parties need to do is to tell the country that they are a coalition," says academic-turned-political activist Yogendra Yadav. "You are a coalition only when you have the semblance of seat-sharing at least. The second most obvious thing is to tell the country which are the five big things you are going to do if you come to power." Sadly, I.N.D.I.A. seems to have failed on both counts.

During the alliance's Patna conclave in June last year, Mamata had said that what starts from Patna ends up becoming a national movement. If that's true, what happened in Patna on January 28 doesn't augur well for I.N.D.I.A. Where the BJP has already launched its first election campaign, the alliance has yet to display the imagination, leadership and political savvy to hold it together. The mandates have been decisive in the past several polls. Opposition parties will need to demonstrate more decisiveness if they have to put up a show of a fight this general election. ■

*–with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Amitabh Srivastava and Amarnath K. Menon*